

# Michiko Kakutani's 10 Favorite Books of 2013

By Michiko Kakutani

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**THE GOLDFINCH** by Donna Tartt (Little, Brown & Company). In this astonishing Dickensian novel, Ms. Tartt uses her myriad talents — her tactile prose, her knowledge of her characters' inner lives, her instinct for suspense — to immerse us in a fully imagined fictional world that reminds us of the wonderful stay-up-all-night pleasures of reading. The novel is at once a thriller involving the theft of a famous Dutch painting; a panoramic portrait of New York (and America) in the post-9/11 era; and an old-fashioned coming-of-age story about an orphan named Theo who, with his best friend Boris, one of the great recent fictional creations, will enter the pantheon of classic buddy acts alongside Laurel and Hardy, Vladimir and Estragon, and Pynchon's Mason and Dixon.

**THE EXAMINED LIFE: HOW WE LOSE AND FIND OURSELVES** by Stephen Grosz (W. W. Norton & Company). Despite its self-help-like title, this moving book of patient portraits by the psychoanalyst Stephen Grosz will make the reader think of Freud's keenly observed and literary-minded case studies. Writing with sympathy and insight, Mr. Grosz distills 25 years of work into a series of slim, piercing chapters that read like a combination of Chekhov and Oliver Sacks. As someone who helps his patients connect the dots in their lives, Mr. Grosz suggests, as Isak Dinesen once wrote, that "all sorrows can be borne if you put them into a story or tell a story about them."

**THANK YOU FOR YOUR SERVICE** by David Finkel (Sarah Crichton Books/Farrar, Straus & Giroux). This heartbreaking book is a sequel of sorts to Mr. Finkel's 2009 "The Good Soldiers," which provided an intimate picture of the Iraq war as seen through the eyes of members of an Army battalion sent to Baghdad during the surge. Here Mr. Finkel, an editor and writer for The Washington Post, tracks the lives of some of those same soldiers after their return home: their efforts to cope with physical injuries, post-traumatic stress disorder and the difficulties of readjusting to

civilian life. The soldiers and their families talk with immense candor and eloquence about their experiences, and the reader finishes this book wondering why the Department of Veterans Affairs cannot provide better, more accessible care for the country's wounded warriors, whose battles did not end on the front lines.

**CLAIRE OF THE SEA LIGHT** by Edwidge Danticat (Alfred A. Knopf). The perennial subjects of Ms. Danticat's fiction and nonfiction — the weight of Haiti's violent history, its extreme poverty and the diaspora they have created — are addressed indirectly in this novel through the fablelike story of a 7-year-old named Claire who lives in the “small and unlucky” town of Ville Rose, some 20 miles south of Port-au-Prince. Ms. Danticat delineates the lives of Claire, her desperately poor father, her mother (who died giving birth to Claire) and their neighbors with pointillist precision, showing how disappointment and loss haunt the people of Ville Rose, and how love can endure in the face of death and departure.

**AFTER THE MUSIC STOPPED: THE FINANCIAL CRISIS, THE RESPONSE, AND THE WORK AHEAD** by Alan S. Blinder (The Penguin Press). The story of fiscal irresponsibility and chaos that resulted in the calamitous financial meltdown of 2008 (along with the story of how the Bush and Obama administrations grappled with the unspooling crises) has been told many times before in news accounts and in an array of books. But Alan S. Blinder, a professor of economics and public affairs at Princeton and a former vice chairman of the Federal Reserve Board, gives us an incredibly useful and wide-angled overview in this volume. The book also benefits from his cleareyed prose and nimble gifts as an explainer, gifts that approach those of Bill Clinton when it comes to making complex economic issues and policies understandable to the lay reader.

**JOHNNY CASH: THE LIFE** by Robert Hilburn (Little, Brown & Company). Johnny Cash's life was a country song full of love, heartbreak and melodrama, and it's chronicled in this thoughtful biography with authority and insight. Mr. Hilburn, the longtime chief music critic for The Los Angeles Times, attempts to separate legend from the historical record (the singer once admitted he “never let facts interfere with a good story”), and writes persuasively about Cash's trajectory as an artist — his place in a changing country music scene, his mythologizing of American life, and his eclectic influences (including gospel, blues and traditional folk). More compelling than Cash's well-known

struggles with drugs and drink is Mr. Hilburn's detailed account of Cash's comeback in the 1990s through his collaboration with the producer Rick Rubin and his return to the sort of tough, unsentimental music that made his name so many decades earlier.

**MY BELOVED WORLD** by Sonia Sotomayor (Alfred A. Knopf). This memoir by Supreme Court Justice Sotomayor charts her journey from a New York housing project to Princeton University and Yale Law School to the highest court in the land with intimacy and candor. She writes in evocative, plain-spoken prose about growing up in the Bronx in the 1960s and '70s, when gangs were carving up the neighborhood and drug use was widespread. And she describes the discipline and perseverance she learned as a child coping with diabetes and the chaos generated at home by her father's drinking. She became fascinated in her youth with the idea of becoming a lawyer or judge while watching "Perry Mason," and when she first became a federal judge in 1992, she says she realized "this fish has found her pond."

**BIG DATA: A REVOLUTION THAT WILL TRANSFORM HOW WE LIVE, WORK, AND THINK** by Viktor Mayer-Schönberger and Kenneth Cukier (Eamon Dolan/Houghton Mifflin Harcourt). Given the vacuuming up (and storing) of massive amounts of data by the likes of Google, Facebook, Amazon and the National Security Agency, few books could be more timely than this illuminating study. The authors argue that big-data analytics is revolutionizing the way we see and process the world — they go so far as to compare its consequences to those of the Gutenberg printing press — and they provide a fascinating (and alarming) survey of its effect on just about everything, including business, politics, science, governance, medicine and, of course, privacy.

**HOW TO GET FILTHY RICH IN RISING ASIA** by Mohsin Hamid (Riverhead Books). Though this book is not the chilling tour de force that Mr. Hamid's 2007 novel "The Reluctant Fundamentalist" was, it remains a showcase for its author's audacious talents. Set in an unnamed country that resembles Pakistan and couched in the form of a self-help manual, this inventive novel recounts the 70-odd-year life of an unnamed hero who journeys from an impoverished village to a sprawling city and who makes — and loses — a fortune in the water ("bottled hydration") business. It's both an affecting and highly specific tale of love and ambition, and a larger metaphorical look at the startling social and economic changes that are sweeping through "rising Asia" and changing the lives of millions along the way.

**TENTH OF DECEMBER: STORIES** by George Saunders (Random House). No one writes more powerfully about disenfranchised Americans — those ordinary folks struggling to pay the bills, make the rent, hold onto detested jobs — than Mr. Saunders. If his earlier story collections like “CivilWarLand in Bad Decline” and “Pastoralia” reverberated with black humor reminiscent of Nathanael West and Kurt Vonnegut, his latest offering bears more of a resemblance to Sherwood Anderson’s “Winesburg, Ohio.” Though there are still brush strokes of surrealism and satire here, the humor tends to be more muted, the focus more firmly glued on his characters’ frustrations, loneliness and difficulty in connecting with others. Sentiment has always lurked beneath the surface of Mr. Saunders’s antic prose, but there is new sympathy for his creations in these pages, an emphasis on how bad luck, impulsive decisions and a lack of resources can snowball into violence or catastrophe or simply derail long cherished dreams.

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